DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Why Does Order Matter in Learning Torah?

Derech Hashem, Introduction

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Introduction **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Sunday 27 December 2020

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Who was the Ramhal?

The series opens with some history, because, as the Rabbi put it, "you can't just learn a book without understanding who wrote it, when it was written, why it was written."

The Ramhal, Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto, lived in the 18th century. He was born in Padua in Italy in the early 1700s, grew up there and studied at the university there. By the age of 20 he was already known as a great mekubal. He was trained in many disciplines, loved art and poetry, and wrote with a clear, rational and orderly style.

The Rabbi called him one of his favourite hakhamim, second only to the Rambam. Like the Rambam, he stood head and shoulders above everyone in his time, and what stands out in both is their seder: everything is organised and builds brick upon brick. For that reason Derech Hashem is not a book you can drop in and out of. A single chapter can be learned on its own, but the full picture only comes from seeing each brick in its order.

His most famous book is Mesillat Yesharim, the staple musar book of the yeshivah world: "If you've been to yeshivah and haven't learned Mesillat Yesharim, you haven't really been to yeshivah." The Vilna Gaon, who lived just after him, said that had the Ramhal been alive he would have walked from Vilna to Italy to meet him, and for that book alone would have considered him his teacher.

The Ramhal and the Rambam: Kabbalah and philosophy

One big difference separates the two. The Rambam was a philosopher, a doctor, a writer on astronomy and on Mishnah, and a posek. He makes no use of Kabbalah at all and rejects the whole concept of Sefirot. The Rambam lived in the 12th century, before the Zohar was publicly revealed (the Rabbi left the question of its authorship for another time).

The Ramhal, by contrast, relies heavily on Kabbalah, and much of his philosophy is built on it. What makes him unique is that he bridges the two, making a hybrid of Kabbalah and philosophy. Many people who speak about Kabbalah repeat what they have read without being able to explain why. The Ramhal makes Kabbalah rational and palatable. The Rabbi noted that it has been said that every line of Derech Hashem is Kabbalah, yet the book never

mentions the word. He also mentioned the Leshem, grandfather of Rav Elyashiv, as a rare example of a mekubal who could also philosophise behind the Kabbalah.

His Hebrew is like the Rambam's: straightforward and clear, unlike some of the Rishonim, who take time to decipher.

Controversy and a short life

"People who are unique have controversies," and the more unique, the bigger the controversy. The Rambam's books were burned, and Rabbenu Yonah later regretted it, yet the Rambam became the most accepted of all.

The Ramhal faced the same. The historical context matters: only about fifty years earlier Shabbetai Sevi, the false mashiah, had used Kabbalah, so people were deeply suspicious of self-proclaimed kabbalists. Here was a young man teaching Kabbalah at 20, and clean-shaven too (he held, following Kabbalah, that a beard is grown only in the Land of Israel). Controversy grew, and he was hounded out of Italy to Amsterdam, which was more liberal. There he worked, continued writing and teaching, and flourished. At 35 he made aliyah to Akko, and he died three years later at the age of 38. In that short life he wrote around 20 books, most of which we no longer have, and 150 poems corresponding to the 150 chapters of Tehillim.

The four parts of the book

The book is called Derech Hashem, the Way of Hashem, because it sets out the principles of how Hashem runs the world. It has four parts:

1. Hashem: what He is and how He operates, as far as we can understand.
2. Hashgahah: how Hakadosh Barukh Hu relates to human beings.
3. The soul (ruah and neshamah) and prophecy.
4. Avodah: how we serve Hashem and the reasons for the misvot.

The orchard and the forest

The Rabbi read selected paragraphs of the introduction, the only part of the book he said he would skip through. The opening paragraph, he said, "sums up the Ramhal."

Knowing things in their exact order, says the Ramhal, compared with knowing the same facts without order, is like the difference between a beautiful orchard with paths and neat rows of planting and the same plants growing in a confused forest. The Rabbi's illustration: the same patch of ground, the same plants, but in one the apples, pears and grapes are mixed together with weeds, and in the other there are five neat rows. Or the same food served beautifully, versus thrown together so that you lose your appetite.

He applied this sharply to our own time: "Jewish education today is exactly like that. There's lots of knowledge, lots of things being taught, but everything's being taught in a forest." Details are taught without kelalim, the principles, and without a sense of where each thing fits. We hear one shiur here and another there, and come away with facts that are all mixed up.

The Ramhal adds that for a person who loves to learn, disordered knowledge becomes a burden: he toils but does not enjoy it, because a great part of wisdom is relativity,

understanding how one thing relates to another. His desire remains unsatisfied and he is pained by it. The one who knows things with their principles sees clearly, wants to learn more, and progresses with pleasure. The Rabbi shared from his own experience that he only understood things three or four years into yeshivah, because nobody taught him the principles and he had to gather them himself. There are people learning fifteen or twenty years who still only have facts: "and that's tragic."

Principles, not details

No human being, however clever, can know every detail. The answer is to get the kelal. Every principle contains many details, and once you have the principle you can trace any detail you meet back to its source.

The Rabbi qualified this: when training to be a rav or dayan you must master the details of a specific topic, and that is hard on the brain. But in broad learning, "don't get bogged down in details. Get the principles." If you go the other way, you miss the principles and forget the details too.

The Ramhal's promise and his warning

The Ramhal says he has written a "small book" setting out clearly the principles of our belief and our service of Hashem, so that they sit clear in the mind, without confusion, and settle on the heart. He has placed everything in the best order and in the most precise words, and so he asks the reader to guard it carefully and not overlook a single word, or something important will be hidden. He named the book Derech Hashem because it teaches the principles of the ways of Hashem, revealed through His prophets and the Torah, by which He conducts all of creation.

The Rabbi noted that this careful pace is how the rest of the series would go: from the next class, every paragraph would be examined, starting with Part 1, Chapter 1 on Hakadosh Barukh Hu.

Summary

- The Ramhal (18th century, Padua, Amsterdam, Akko) was, like the Rambam, a master of order and clarity, but unlike the Rambam he built on Kabbalah and made it rational.
- His life was marked by controversy, partly because of suspicion of Kabbalah after Shabbetai Sevi; he died at 38.
- Derech Hashem has four parts: Hashem, hashgahah, the soul and prophecy, and avodah and misvot.
- Knowledge with order is a beautiful orchard; the same knowledge without order is a confusing forest that burdens the learner.
- Learn principles, not just details, and read the Ramhal carefully, since every word is chosen with precision.

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